Surreal scenes greet dry-season visitors: the cadavers of wooden boats, abandoned by the locals, on unevenly dried mudflats. Some people go off-road and drive on to this ‘white Rann’, taking care to avoid any remaining slushy spots. Heat mirages make distant landmarks hover in mid-air. In the moonlight, the salty white terrain glows; without the moon, the Milky Way often lights up the night sky.

Settlements in the Rann are limited to a few *bet*s, or grassy island–plateaus above the salty mudflats. Khadir, about 500 sq. km in size, is one such island that hosts the remains of the ancient city of Dholavira. Discovered in 1967 and excavated only after 1989, Dholavira is among the five largest Harappan cities known today, along with Harappa, Mohenjo-Daro and Ganweriwala in Pakistan, and Rakhigarhi in India. They represent the first-ever urban culture in the subcontinent, with well-planned ‘cities, developed social classes, craft and career specialists, writing and long-distance trade with Mesopotamia, Central Asia, and even with the countries at the mouth of the Red Sea’.[1] As we’ll see, their cultural legacy still thrives in modern Indian culture.

Khadir has no perennial rivers, lakes or springs. It also gets little rain, making it a harsh environment to live in. At least since Harappan times, Khadir has had a shallow potable aquifer. Its farmers have long grown crops like millets (jowar, bajra), green gram (mung) and sesame by supplementing rainwater with groundwater using hand-drawn wells. The archaeological site gets its name from the village of Dholavira (population 2500), a short walk from the ruins.

Further east, in the Little Rann of Kutch, is a wildlife sanctuary that protects the endangered khur, or Asiatic wild ass, a shy, handsome animal that can sprint at 70 km per hour. It lives on a few bets in the Rann. Only a few thousand khurs survive, though luckily, their numbers have risen since my last visit. The sanctuary also has wetlands where local and migratory birds nest, including cranes, storks and flamingos. The flamingo—delicately perched on one leg, neck down, looking for shrimp—seems to me an apt symbol of vulnerability in this era of climate change. Here and there a desolate camp is planted upon the crusty dirt, where a family or two join forces to eke out a living by mining salt from the saline groundwater; this is a major local industry. Legend has it that when a salt worker dies, the soles